

THE LAWS, RIGHTS, AND DUTIES OF WAR

THE HAGUE CONVENTIONS (1899, 1907)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

International law

BEFORE

1863 The Lieber Code sets out rules of conduct for the military during the Civil War.

1864 The first Geneva Convention protects the wounded and noncombatants during conflict.

1868 The St. Petersburg Declaration proscribes the use of certain types of weapons.

AFTER

1954 The Hague Convention on the Protection of Cultural Property is signed, focusing solely on the protection of cultural heritage during war.

1993 The UN approves the Chemical Weapons Convention, which outlaws the production, stockpiling, and use of chemical weapons.

The Hague Conventions were the first international treaties laying out the customs and rules of warfare. They were agreed on at international peace conferences convened in The Hague in the Netherlands in 1899 and 1907. The background to the agreements was the increasingly brutal and far-reaching scope of war in the 19th and early 20th century. The balance of power across Europe and beyond had been destabilized. As nation-states grew, they vied for territory, raw materials, and trade. Nations assembled powerful armed forces, and an armaments race developed, particularly involving Britain,